UMKC Impact & Translation Series

Finding Your Founding Team

Helping you move your work beyond the university

Forming the right team is one of the most important early decisions when work begins to move beyond the university into real-world use. This whitepaper distills best practices from both national startup ecosystems and UMKC's own experience to help faculty and graduate students identify, recruit, and structure an effective founding team.

Readers will learn (1) which core roles matter most at the very beginning, (2) how to balance skills, motivation, and culture, and (3) pragmatic steps to move from idea toward a structured effort capable of reaching real-world use..

UITS Whitepaper

This whitepaper is part of the **UMKC Impact & Translation Series (UITS)** - a set of short videos and supporting materials designed to help faculty think more clearly about how their work can move beyond the university and into real-world use.

The videos introduce core ideas. This document goes deeper on one of those ideas: **forming the right team for impact.**

Introduction

A brilliant invention rarely becomes a successful company without a complementary team behind it.

At UMKC, we regularly see that commercialization efforts accelerate when researchers pair their technical insight with partners who excel in market discovery, product development, and early-stage business building.

Yet many university-based founders struggle to know **who** they actually need on day one—and how to persuade talented colleagues to join a venture that is still more promise than paycheck. This guide answers those questions and offers UMKC-specific resources to support your search.

Core Roles for an Early-Stage Academic Startup

Not all work requires forming a startup team. Some innovations move forward through licensing, partnerships, or adoption within existing organizations. However, when the path involves building something new, team formation becomes a central factor in whether that effort succeeds.

Building a company out of a research breakthrough is equal parts science, story, and hustle. In the frenzy of grant deadlines and publication pressures, faculty founders often default to a lone-inventor model - only to discover that investors and industry partners evaluate ventures first on team completeness, second on technology maturity.

Evidence from the Kauffman Foundation and Startup Genome shows that **balanced founding teams raise 30–40 % more capital and reach product-market fit twice as fast** as solo founders.

The lesson is clear: your first three seats can either multiply or mute the value of your IP. Instead of hiring a full C-suite, focus on covering perspectives that mirror the design-thinking lens - desirability, viability, and feasibility.

At UMKC we frame these perspectives as the Problem Expert, Business Developer, and Technology Developer. One person may initially wear two hats, but explicit ownership of each lens keeps priorities aligned and prevents critical blind spots.

1. **Problem Expert (Visionary / Idealist)** – lives and breathes the user problem, drives customer discovery, and keeps the venture anchored in unmet need.
2. **Business Developer** – designs the business model, validates willingness-to-pay, secures early funding, and builds strategic partnerships.
3. **Technology Developer** – turns lab-scale insights into a functional, scalable prototype under tight resource constraints.

These roles give a startup just enough "3-legged stool" stability to navigate uncertainty without premature hierarchy.

UMKC Insight: *In past faculty/student-founded companies such as* ***EyeVerify****, founders reported that aligning on these three roles early prevented later confusion about who owned regulatory strategy, grant writing, and product iterations.*

Deciding Who Will Leave the Lab

Leaving the security of an academic appointment for a fledgling company can feel risky, but someone must step out of the lab and into the market full-time if the venture is to gain momentum. This section lays out a structured approach for deciding who that person (or people) should be and how to make the leap with minimal friction.

Why Someone Must Go All-In

Startups move at a tempo universities cannot match. Customer validation, prototype iterations, and investor conversations often happen in cycles measured in days—not semesters.

A founder who is 100 % dedicated can:

- Shorten feedback loops by talking with users, suppliers, and regulators daily.
- Signal commitment to investors, partners, and future hires.
- Catch issues early (e.g., manufacturing glitches, reimbursement hurdles) before they derail project timelines.

UMKC Insight: *Many seed funds will not invest until at least one technically knowledgeable founder has left the university and shows "skin in the game."*

Assessing Personal Fit and Readiness

Ask each potential founder to self-evaluate on three vectors:

Question	Indicators You're Ready	Red Flags
Motivation	Energized by ambiguity; intrinsic drive to see the tech used in the real world	Prefers structured milestones and academic recognition
Risk Tolerance	Comfortable with 12–18 months of variable pay; views setbacks as learning	Requires guaranteed salary; highly risk-averse
Influence	Ability to rally team, mentors, and early adopters	Limited network beyond academia

A "yes" across at least two vectors suggests a strong candidate for the pioneering role.

Employment & Leave Pathways at UMKC

UMKC offers multiple mechanisms to reduce personal and departmental risk:

- **Entrepreneurial Leave** – Up to one year of unpaid leave while retaining tenure clock status. Departments often allow a part-time return if the venture fails.
- **Reduced Appointment (0.50–0.75 FTE)** – Faculty retain benefits while freeing critical weekdays for startup duties.
- **Joint Appointment** – Split time between UMKC and the startup; common when grant funding still flows through the university.
- **Graduate-Student Fellows** – Grad students may dedicate a semester via internship credit or a paid fellowship funded by an SBIR supplement.

Contact OTT and OC early to navigate paperwork and conflict-of-interest disclosures.

Funding Bridges for Early Salaries

Leaving the lab is easier when initial salary support is lined up:

- **Phase I SBIR/STTR Grants** – Allow up to $264 K (NIH) in technical salary and consultant costs.
- **FFAR Seeding Solutions or DoD–xTech Prizes** – Non-dilutive cash that can fund 6-12 months of runway.
- **Founders' Agreements** – Clarify whether university IP licensing fees are deferred to preserve cash.

Handling IP & Conflict-of-Interest (COI)

The founder-as-employee dynamic introduces potential COI concerns. Mitigate by:

- **Drafting a Management Plan** with the Office of Technology Transfer that specifies roles, reporting lines, and disclosure cadence.
- **Separating lab resources** – Use off-campus servers, tooling, and grant accounts for company work.

- **Documenting IP boundaries** – Identify which data and inventions stay with UMKC versus the startup.

Timing the Spin-Out

A practical rule: spin out once you can explain your value proposition in one sentence and show a benchtop demo that proves feasibility. Waiting for the "perfect" dataset often means missing the market window. On-campus prototyping resources (e.g., the School of Science and Engineering Machine Shop or the Innovation Studio's 3-D printing facilities) can bridge capability gaps during the handoff.

With a clear readiness assessment, structured UMKC pathways, and early funding options, founders can commit fully and confidently to building outside the university walls.

Motivating and Attracting Co-Founders

Finding co-founders is less about posting a "help wanted" ad and more about telling an **irresistible story of impact and shared upside**. High-caliber partners can work anywhere; they join startups that satisfy their drive for autonomy, mastery, and purpose.

Below is a structured approach to locating—and winning—the right people.

Clarify the Value Proposition *for* Co-Founders

Before you recruit, articulate:

1. **Mission Impact:** What societal or industry pain will you relieve? (e.g., "reduce hospital readmissions by 20 % in five years").
2. **Unique Advantage:** Why is this team uniquely positioned to solve it? Highlight your IP, data sets, or early validation.
3. **Upside & Timeline:** Provide a realistic five-year outlook: milestone-based valuation targets, grant pathways, and liquidity scenarios.

UMKC Tip: *Draft a one-page "Founder Pitch" that distills these points. It becomes the leave-behind for coffee chats and conference follow-ups.*

Where to Find Talent

Great co-founders often emerge from overlapping circles of expertise, passion, and opportunity—so focus your search where those circles naturally intersect. The table below highlights high-yield talent pools and concrete ways to approach them.

Talent Pool	Strengths	How to Engage
UMKC Ecosystem (graduate programs, E-Scholars, etc.)	Technical expertise, local commitment	Host info sessions; collaborate on capstone projects

UMKC Innovation Center (including Office of Commercialization)	Expertise, contacts in ecosystem, resources and funging	Contact through Office of Commercialization
Regional Industry Pros (KC Animal Health Corridor, Cerner alumni, Garmin engineers)	Domain knowledge, commercialization chops	Attend niche meetups; leverage LinkedIn warm intros via faculty advisory boards
MBA & JD Candidates (Bloch School, Law School)	Market strategy, regulatory insight	Offer semester-long venture projects; advertise equity-for-sweat roles
Online Platforms (CoFoundersLab, Slack groups like #StartupsKC)	Diverse, remote candidates	Post mission-centric role briefs; conduct async "get-to-know" sprints

Crafting the Outreach

Craft an outreach strategy that instantly communicates why your venture matters, what you need, and how a potential co-founder can share in the upside—this first impression should spark curiosity and action.

- **Role Brief:** ½-page description detailing problem space, expected weekly commitment, and equity range (e.g., 10-20 % vesting over four years).
- **Story Hook:** Lead with the mission, not the technology. "Help 300 M diabetics avoid blindness" moves hearts more than "utilize ML for ophthalmic imaging."
- **Social Proof:** Mention advisors, early grants (e.g., $20 K Digital Sandbox), or pilot partners to de-risk the opportunity.

Evaluating Fit Beyond the Résumé

Résumé screening narrows the field, but true alignment emerges only when you probe values, adaptability, and collaboration style through structured, real-world interactions.

- **Competency Matrix:** Rate each candidate (1-5) on technical depth, market acumen, fund-raising comfort, and network reach.
- **Culture Interviews:** Ask scenario-based questions ("Tell me about a time data disproved your hypothesis—what did you do?") to probe flexibility and ego control.
- **Trial Project:** Engage finalists in a two-week sprint—customer calls, prototype tweak, or NSF I-Corps assignment. Observe follow-through and communication cadence.

Incentive Structures That Work

Motivation compounds when compensation reflects contribution; combine equity, modest cash, and professional-growth perks to keep co-founders committed through the roller-coaster of early execution.

- **Equity with Milestone Vesting:** Allocate additional slices when key targets (e.g., FDA 510(k) submission) are met.

- **Hybrid Salary-Equity:** Use grant or accelerator stipends (up to $50 K via LaunchKC) for modest pay plus meaningful stock.
- **Professional Growth:** Offer conference travel, co-author credit on publications, or access to cutting-edge lab equipment.

Leverage UMKC & Regional Resources

UMKC and Kansas City host a dense support network—tap these programs, mentors, and grants to accelerate team formation and reduce early-stage risk.

- **UMKC Innovation Center Mentor Network:** 40+ alumni founders and investors available for warm referrals.
- **Bloch School's Entrepreneurship Scholars (E-Scholars):** Allows non-students to audit sessions focused on team dynamics and legal basics.
- **KCSourceLink Multicultural Business Coalition:** Expands reach into under-represented founder talent.

UMKC Insight: *EyeVerify secured its CEO through contacts at the UMKC Innovation Center, accelerating Series A by six months. Likewise, Evolution Pervious brought in an ex-construction VP who navigated ASTM standards—something the research team lacked.*

By combining a compelling mission narrative with structured outreach, objective fit assessments, and UMKC's resource stack, you can convert interested contacts into committed co-founders who share both risk and reward.

Building a Trustworthy & Diverse Team Culture

Early-stage startups succeed or fail on the quality of their relationships. Trust fuels fast iteration, honest customer feedback, and the stamina to survive inevitable pivots.

Research from Google's Project Aristotle and MIT's Human Dynamics Lab shows that teams with high psychological safety and equal conversational turn-taking outperform their peers in both execution speed and creativity.

A practical trust-building playbook for UMKC founders

1. **Start with a micro-commitment:** Before anyone signs incorporation documents, work together on a time-boxed experiment—e.g., two weeks of customer interviews or a pitch-deck sprint. Observe reliability and communication styles under light pressure.
2. **Establish shared values early:** Draft a one-page "Team Charter" that lists why the venture matters, how decisions are made, and what behaviors are non-negotiable (e.g., data privacy, respect for time). Revisit quarterly.
3. **Create psychological safety:** Encourage dissent by rotating the "devil's advocate" role in meetings and explicitly praising well-argued counterpoints. This normalizes productive disagreement and prevents groupthink.

4. **Default to transparency:** Maintain a living project board (e.g., Trello, Asana) that makes goals, blockers, and responsibilities visible to everyone. Use weekly retros to surface concerns before they fester.
5. **Resolve conflicts quickly:** Adopt a lightweight dispute-resolution process—start with one-on-one discussion, escalate to a neutral mentor (UMKC Innovation Center offers volunteer advisors), and document any decisions that affect equity or IP.
6. **Celebrate small wins**: Shared rituals—demo days, customer-interview milestones, monthly lunches—reinforce camaraderie and buffer stress.
7. **Leverage diversity as an asset:** Founding teams with varied domains, genders, and cultural backgrounds generate 30–50 % more patents and venture returns. When recruiting, set explicit diversity goals and tap UMKC networks like Women in STEM, the Bloch School Entrepreneurship Scholars, and KCSourceLink's Multicultural Business Coalition.

By institutionalizing these practices, founders transform trust from a vague ideal into a measurable advantage.

Structuring Equity & Responsibilities

Getting equity right early can prevent costly disputes later. The goal is to align incentives with **future** value creation, protect the company if someone departs, and leave head-room for future hires and investors.

Guiding Principles

- **Contribution over credentials:** Reward the work founders will do, not just past titles or academic rank.
- **Simplicity beats precision:** An easily understood split that everyone feels is "fair enough" beats a mathematically perfect but convoluted cap table.
- **Protect the mission:** Use vesting and governance safeguards so a founder who disengages cannot block financing or pivots.

Common Split Models

No single equity formula fits every founding team; the right model reflects each person's risk, time commitment, and expected value creation over the next two years. Use the options below as starting points, then adapt to your venture's realities.

Model	When to Use	Typical % Allocation
Equal Split	Founders commit similar time and risk from day one	33 / 33 / 33 (three founders)
Role-Weighted	Founders have clearly different day-to-day load (e.g., CEO full-time, CSO half-time)	50 / 30 / 20

Dynamic / Milestone	Significant uncertainty about who will raise capital or build product	Start at 20 / 20 / 20 with additional 40 % released on agreed milestones

UMKC Snapshot: *LymphFit used a milestone-based approach that released extra shares once the COO secured SBIR Phase I funding.*

Vesting Mechanics

Equity is a promise of future value; vesting turns that promise into earned ownership by tying shares to ongoing contribution and time in the trenches. The frameworks below outline standard schedules and investor-friendly safeguards.

- **Standard Vesting:** 4-year vest with 1-year cliff; monthly thereafter.
- **Reverse Vesting:** Founders purchase shares up-front but the company can repurchase unvested shares at nominal cost if they leave.
- **Acceleration Clauses:** Single-trigger (change of control) or double-trigger (change of control + termination) acceleration helps founders in an acquisition but can deter investors - use sparingly.

Founder Roles & Decision Rights

Agree early on **who is CEO** (single point for investors) and how major decisions require consent:

- **Day-to-Day Authority:** The CEO manages budget and hiring; CSO leads R&D road-map; COO handles operations.
- **Reserved Matters:** Any new share issuance, IP sale, or debt financing requires unanimous founder approval until Series A.
- **Board Composition:** Start with a three-member board (two founders + one independent advisor) to add external perspective without losing control.

Setting Up an Option Pool

Allocate 10–15 % of total shares for future employees, advisors, and the scientific advisory board. Option pools usually sit **above** founder ownership in pre-money valuation calculations, so plan the pool size before negotiating with investors.

Legal Steps at UMKC

Even the fairest equity split can unravel without airtight paperwork; follow these campus-friendly legal checkpoints to lock in ownership, minimize tax surprises, and stay investor-ready.

1. **Stock Purchase Agreements & 83(b) Election:** File within 30 days of share issuance to avoid adverse tax treatment.
2. **Founder Service Agreements:** Spell out roles, time commitment, and IP assignment.
3. **Local Clinics & Resources:** UMKC School of Law Entrepreneur Clinic offers free reviews, and KCSourceLink's Resource Navigator lists vetted startup attorneys who offer fixed-fee formation packages.

With a transparent equity plan, clear governance, and solid legal footing, founders can focus on building value rather than re-litigating who owns what.

Action Steps for UMKC Researchers

The preceding sections lay the groundwork; now it's time to act. Use the checklist below as a 30-day sprint to move your idea from concept toward an investable venture:

1. **Map your gaps:** Use the Core Roles table to identify missing strengths.
2. **Test culture fit:** Run a two-week micro-project with prospective co-founders.
3. **Draft a Founders' Agreement:** Address IP contributions, decision rights, vesting, and conflict resolution.
4. **Leverage UMKC Resources:**
    - **Office of Commercialization (techcomm@umkc.edu)** – market assessments, go-to-market strategy.
    - **Office of Technology Transfer (patents@umkc.edu)** – disclosures, protection strategy.
    - **Digital Sandbox KC** – proof-of-concept grants.
    - **KCSourceLink** – community resources for startups.
5. **Schedule a Venture First-Step Meeting** with the Office of Commercialization and Office of Technology Transfer to align on patent strategy.

Guiding Question:

Who would need to be involved to move this work beyond the university, and what roles would they need to play?

Conclusion

The people involved in moving your work forward will shape whether it reaches meaningful impact beyond the university.

By intentionally balancing expertise, motivation, equity, and by drawing on UMKC's growing commercialization ecosystem you can transform lab insights into market-ready innovations faster and with less friction.

Key Takeaways

- **Prioritize people, not positions.** Anchor around complementary mindsets—Problem Expert, Technology Developer, and Business Developer—before chasing formal titles.
- **Commit to trust and transparency.** Psychological safety, clear communication, and fast conflict resolution outlast any single grant or prototype.
- **Design future-focused incentives.** Simple equity splits, four-year vesting, and an option pool keep founders, early hires, and investors rowing in the same direction.

Your Next Move

1. **Book a 30-minute consult** with the Office of Commercialization to map your current team and identify gaps.
2. **Run a micro-sprint** of two weeks of customer discovery or prototype refinement with at least one potential co-founder to test working chemistry.
3. **Draft a lightweight Founders' Agreement** using templates from the UMKC Law Entrepreneur Clinic to capture roles, vesting, and IP assignment.

Great companies rarely emerge from lone genius; they grow from small, diverse teams united by purpose and empowered by supportive ecosystems. UMKC's resources - from mentor networks to prototyping facilities - are here to help you recruit that team, share the risk, and amplify the impact of your research on society.

Resources & Contacts

UMKC Office of Commercialization
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📍 Website: www.umkcinnovates.com/tech-commercialization

UMKC Office of Technology Transfer
Director: Eric Anderson, JD MBA
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📞 Phone: 816-235-5091
📍 Website: https://ori.umkc.edu/facilities-compliance-and-commercialization/commercialization/process/submit-an-invention-disclosure.html

- **UMKC Innovation Center Workshops:** monthly sessions on customer discovery, investor readiness, and founder agreements.
- **Recommended Reading:** Jared Friedman's *How to Spin Your Scientific Research Out of a University* (YC), Bart van Grevenhof's *Building Your Startup Team*, Robert Strohmeyer's *Finding and Building a Founding Team*.